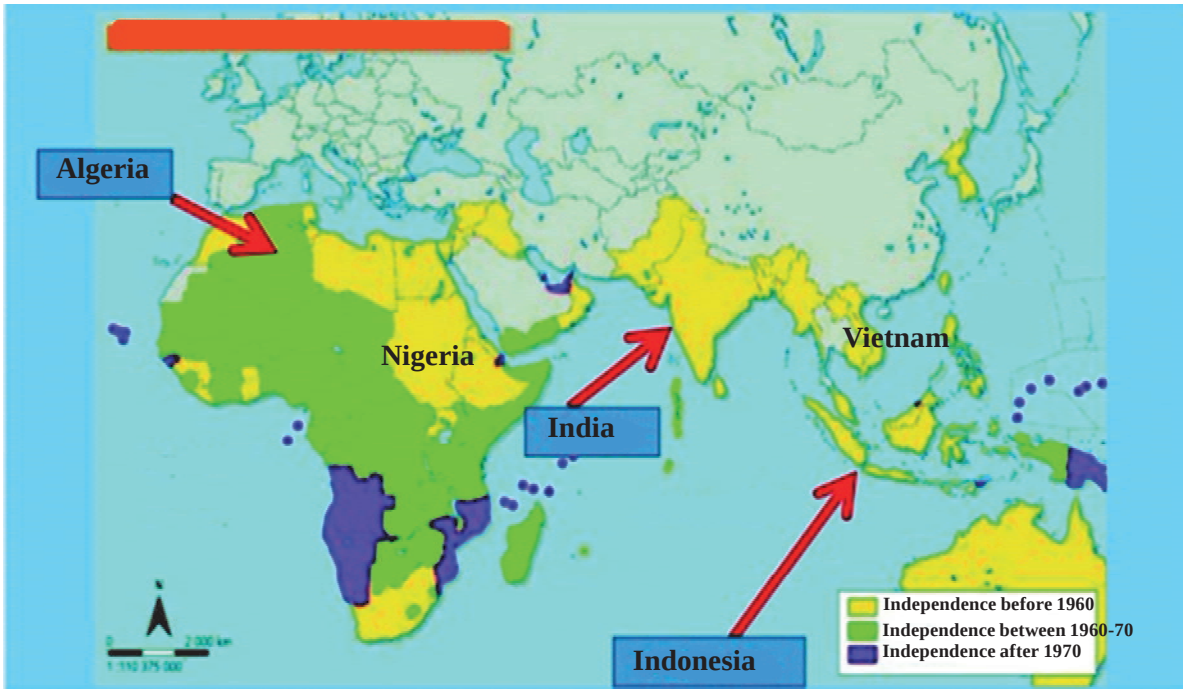
10

End of Colonialism and the Cold War

You know that the colonial regime in India and Pakistan came to an end in August 1947 and these two countries became independent nation states. Within 30 years of the end of the Second World War, from 1945 to 1975, all the countries of Asia and Africa threw off the colonial yoke and became independent nations. Indonesia gained freedom in 1945, India and Pakistan in 1947, Burma (Myanmar) and Ceylon (Sri Lanka) in 1948, and several other countries thereafter. China became an independent republic following the communist revolution in 1949. At the same time, other East Asian countries such as Korea and the Philippines, too, gained independence. The world map was, thus, transformed between 1940 and 1980. The process that ended colonial rule and led to the establishment of independent governments in different countries is called decolonization.

Map 10.1: Decolonisation of Asia and Africa



We learned about the process of colonization in class 9. You will remember that it had many different aspects. First, political power in the colonies lay in the hands of the imperialist powers such as Britain. Second, the colonies were economically exploited – raw materials were procured cheaply from them, processed in European factories and the finished goods were sold in the international markets; also, the colonies were heavily taxed to generate revenue for the colonial governments. Third, the people in the

colonies were indoctrinated to see themselves as uncivilized, with the European nations being the messengers of civilization. They were made to believe that their well-being lay in internalizing and accepting European culture and thinking. Colonialism could end only after the people of the colonies were able to achieve political and economic freedom and regain their self-respect by liberating themselves culturally and ideologically.

We learnt in the previous class that Britain, France, Holland, Portugal and Japan were the dominant imperialist countries that established their colonies in America, Asia and Africa. We also learnt that most of the colonies in North and South America fought their imperialist masters to gain their freedom towards the end of the 18th century and the beginning of the 19th century. In this chapter we shall learn about the process of decolonization in the 20th century.

What are the differences between an independent country and a colony? Discuss in class.

10.1 International political scenario after the Second World War

The old imperialist European countries were economically crippled by the cost of fighting the Second World War. France, Holland, Britain as well as Japan were disrupted by the war and these countries had to seek the support of the United States of America (USA) to rebuild their shattered economies. After the war, the USA and the USSR emerged as the two most powerful countries in the world. They both opposed colonialism and wanted the colonies to gain independence. So they began to put pressure on Britain and other imperialist countries to grant freedom to their colonies.

The war had one significant economic impact on the colonies. Before the war, colonies like India were economically indebted to Britain. But, during the war, Britain took huge loans from its colonial government in India to sustain its war effort. Thus, instead of Britain getting resources from India it was now indebted to India. The cost of retaining the India as its colony after the war became too high for the British exchequer to bear.

The Second World War was a global battle to defend freedom and democracy, with Britain and the Allied Powers opposing Germany and the Axis powers. Having fought to defend democratic freedom, these imperialist countries could no longer refuse to grant freedom to their colonies after the war. The indigenous freedom movements in these colonies had also picked up momentum during the war, especially in the initial phase when Germany was successful against its opponents. Seeing their colonial masters weakened, the colonies seized the opportunity to gain their freedom. There were armed insurrections in many colonies. In India, too, the colonial army and police began to side with nationalists. The colonial rulers that the old methods of controlling and ruling their colonies were no longer effective. Weakened by the war, the European countries could no longer bear the economic burden of retaining their colonies.

But the problem they now faced was to ensure unity and stability in the colonies during the transition of power. The imperialist countries also wanted to ensure that the colonies adopted economic and political policies that protected their own interests. This task was made easier because they were handing over power to the very classes they had nurtured to help them administer their colonies. These classes included local kings, landowners, wealthy merchants and the educated middle class.

There was one other significant development during this time. Soviet Russia began extending support to political parties in the colonies that followed communist and socialist ideologies and wanted to usher in fundamental social change through a people's revolution. These parties sought to establish the rule of the peasants and workers by ousting the upper class of maharajas, nawabs, landowners and capitalists.

In those days, the countries of the world were divided into two power blocs. One bloc comprised he USSR and its allied countries and the other bloc comprised the USA and its allied countries. USSR wanted to strengthen its bloc by helping the colonies win their independence. At that time, it extended its support to political parties spearheading revolutionary movements in China, Vietnam, Korea and other countries. It also extended its support to the strong communist parties that were emerging in countries like India and Indonesia.

America did not take a backseat to Russia in this competition to win the allegiance of newly-independent countries. It wanted the colonies to win their freedom before the USSR-backed parties became too powerful and seized power. It wanted the upper classes to capture power and oppose the spread of communism in their countries. The American strategy was to encircle Russia with a string of military bases that could challenge Soviet power if a war broke out in future. This was possible only in the old European colonies, which is why America was committed to these colonies gaining their freedom.

This global competition between USA and USSR had a marked impact on the decolonization process. Both countries were keen to end the colonial system and see the colonies gain their independence. Both also wanted to gain the allegiance of the newly independent countries and influence their policies. As a result, the freedom struggles in some of these countries became enmeshed in the USA-USSR rivalry, examples including Korea and Vietnam in Asia and Namibia and Angola in Africa.

This rivalry laid the ground for the emergence of a new kind of colonialism. Both Russia and America extended large loans to the newly independent countries to win their allegiance and make them indebted. What was, thus, emerging was a new phase of neo-colonialism in which the former colonies were once again controlled through indebtedness and the establishment of military bases on their territory by the two super-powers.

To sum up, it can be said that the end of the Second World War created a situation in which the imperialist countries were left with little choice but to grant independence to their colonies. But, at the same time, these newly independent countries found themselves caught up in the competition between the two super-powers, coming under their sway in some way or the other.

What were the similarities and differences between the situation in Britain and France after the Second World War?

British and French economists claimed on the basis of their assessments that their countries would sink into debt if they retained their colonies. What were the reasons for their claim? Do you think that the same conditions prevailed in these countries before the outbreak of the world war?

What were the similarities and differences in the policies of America and USSR towards the colonial countries?

You must have learnt about 'non-alignment' in the political science chapters. Why do you think non-alignment was important after 1945?

10.2 Nationalist movements in the colonies

The credit for closing the chapter on colonialism must surely go to the people's movements in the colonies that won them their freedom between 1945 and 1975. During the colonial period, almost all the

colonies faced internal insurrections by groups that were affected in some way or other. For example, India witnessed *adivasi* and peasant revolts from as early as 1750 right up to 1950. These included the 1857 revolt, Santhal uprising, 1910 Bhumkal rebellion in Bastar, Telengana peasants' uprising from 1946 to 1950, and so on.

These rebellions were important for two reasons. First, they challenged the colonial powers, even if they were not successful. Second, they challenged the intellectual colonialism by which the ruling powers sought to indoctrinate the people in the colonies. These revolts certainly left their imprint and influenced the thinking of the colonized people even if they were never strong enough to defeat the colonial powers.

Apart from these armed rebellions, peasants, workers, traders and the educated middle class launched movements to seek their demands. Mostly for class specific demands, these movements also left their impact on the colonial governments.

The national freedom movements in the colonies also began to gather momentum. In India, the nationalist movement can be traced back to 1885. It picked up steam after 1905, reaching its peak during the Second World War in 1942, after which it became clear that India would gain its independence from British rule sooner or later.

China, too, had a nationalist movement that began in 1911 and culminated in the communist revolution in 1949. Most Asian and African countries saw the launch of freedom movements during the war years.

You may have read in class 9 about uprisings that occurred in different colonies. Recall what you read about the rebellions in China and Indonesia and share their main aspects with the class.

What were the main phases and events in the Indian freedom movement between 1905 and 1945? Discuss them in class.

The national movements in the colonies faced many challenges. To begin with, the people in most of the colonies were divided into small communities on the basis of tribe, caste, language, region and religion. There was no national identity or spirit to weave this diversity into a nation that represented all its people and worked for the good of all its citizens. The cementing factor that usually brought these different groups together in a common struggle was opposition to foreign rule. The methods used to bring the people together on a common platform were also developed by the colonial rulers themselves. For example, in India, English language and the print media played a key role in unifying the people. Other colonies also used the languages of the colonizing nation, whether English, French or Dutch, to propel their national movements.

The second challenge was that the prominent nationalist leaders in the colonies were mostly educated in the modern liberal tradition, as a result of which they were influenced by democratic, liberal or communist ideologies. On the other hand, the common people were mostly traditional in their outlook, following the traditional practices and paternalistic beliefs of their feudal and tribal communities. So most of the national movements were influenced by these two streams of thought. On the one hand were those who wanted to propagate a nationalist spirit based on modern education and democratic institutions. On the other were those who wanted to promote nationalism based on traditional values and religions. Thus, the thrust for social change and modernism co-existed with the demand to preserve tradition.

A third challenge was that the educated nationalist leaders mostly belonged to the wealthy and elite classes, which made it difficult for them to easily identify with or influence the masses of people who belonged to the poor and exploited classes. Creating a space for the poor to participate and make their voice heard in the national movements was, thus, a difficult task. However, many Congress leaders from the elite class like Gandhiji, Jawaharlal Nehru and Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel were able to transcend their class origins and participate in the peasant, worker and *adivasi* movements. They tried to accommodate the demands and rights of these sections of society in the nationalist movement. But this was not always the case in other countries where the poor were often cut off from the national struggles for freedom.

Another challenge facing the nationalist leaders was that most countries did not have a democratic tradition so it was not an easy task to build up a nationalist movement based on people's participation. India was an exception in this respect. The country had been exposed to democratic practices since 1880 when the British rulers introduced public franchise, though in a limited way, allowing people to elect their representatives to the municipalities. Between 1919 and 1935, popular election was extended to choosing representatives to the provincial assemblies.

In addition, primary education had a wider reach in the Indian population than in other countries, with many colleges and universities for higher education also being established. This education system helped the emergence of an aware middle class that could represent the interests of all classes, castes, religions and regions in the country. On the political front, too, there was a democratic organization, the Congress party, that could lead the national movement. In addition, there were other political parties in the country to represent different ideologies and fight for the rights of different communities, classes and regions.

For these reasons, the democratic system was fairly firmly established in India. This was not the case in most other countries, which lacked such democratic institutions and experiences, the only other exception being Sri Lanka. That is why many of these countries saw their freedom struggles replacing colonial rule with dictatorships or military rule.

Is the spirit of nationalism required to end colonialism and win freedom?

Can people speaking different languages and following different religions constitute a nation? If one language or religion dominates, what impact will it have on the nation?

Is a nation a combination of the rights of peasants, workers, traders, industrialists, landowners, men, women, etc or is it something that goes beyond everyone's rights? Discuss with examples.

What impact did the absence of democratic traditions have on the process of decolonization?

10.3 Decolonisation: some examples

10.3.1 India

The movement against British rule in India gained momentum after 1935. Peasants, workers, *adivasis*, youth, etc in all regions of the country were by then opposing the colonial establishment. The Congress party had assumed the leadership of the national freedom movement under the guidance of Gandhiji. However, tensions began to emerge between the different social classes as it became clear that India

would soon win freedom. *Dalit* leaders like Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar were worried about the fate of the *dalits* once India gained independence. The Muslims had similar concerns. Provinces like Madras (Tamil Nadu) were also apprehensive about their place in an independent India.

The Congress party claimed that it represented the interests of the entire nation so it would be able to deal with conflicting interests objectively, without taking sides. But not everyone was convinced by this claim. Taking advantage of these internal dissensions, the British rulers began inciting the different religious and caste groups to stake their claims, telling them that the Congress party could never represent all sections of Indian society. For example, Mohammed Ali Jinnah, the leader of the Indian Muslim League, began demanding a separate country, Pakistan, for the Muslims.

The national movement was becoming more intense during this phase, with peasant revolts under way in some states and industrial workers in cities organizing strikes and demonstrations. The army and navy were also on the threshold of revolt, with the rebellion of sailors deployed in the Arabian Sea fleet receiving tremendous support from the people.

Assessing the volatile situation, the British government decided to bifurcate India by carving out a new country comprising the Muslim-majority regions in the east and west. The colonial rulers also gave the 500-odd princely states the freedom to decide whether they would like to be integrated into India or Pakistan or remain as independent states. Most of the rulers were willing to merge their states into India but a few large princely states such as Jammu and Kashmir and Hyderabad tried to retain their independent status. However, these rulers had to eventually bow to the dictates of their subjects and agree to merge with India.

You must have already read in the political science chapters the story of how independent India drafted its democratic constitution and how universal adult suffrage was established to enable the people to elect their representatives to the legislative wings of the new government.

10.3.2 Indonesia

Indonesia is a country of islands situated to the south-east of India. You learnt in class 9 how the country became a colony of Holland (the Netherlands). Here we shall learn about Indonesia's story of independence.



Figure 10.1: Sukarno announcing Indonesia's independence in 1945

During the Second World War, Germany defeated Holland and handed over control of Indonesia to its ally Japan. The Japanese did talk of granting independence to the country but, at the same time, they wanted to retain the colony. They began to ruthlessly cut down Indonesia's forests, exploit its mineral resources, expropriate all its commercial crops and subject its people to forced labour. But they did allow some nationalist leaders to continue their struggle for freedom from Dutch colonial rule. Among them was Sukarno who had been imprisoned in Dutch jails for 10 years. The Japanese also encouraged the use of the local language in place of Dutch. But many Indonesian nationalists opposed Japan, saying that its treatment of their country was even more barbaric



Figure 10.2: The leaders of the freedom struggles in Africa, Asia and East Europe at the Bandung Conference in April 1955 - Nehru from India, Kwame Nkrumah from Ghana, Gamal Abdel Nasser from Egypt, Sukarno from Indonesia and Marshal Tito from Yugoslavia

than the Dutch. Nationalist activities, thus, flourished during the period of political instability from 1939 to 1945.

Sukarno declared Indonesia an independent country on August 17, 1945, with Japan's consent, once it became evident that the Japanese faced defeat in the war. Meanwhile, the British army, which had established its control over Indonesia at the time, tried to bring back the Dutch administrative officials. The Indonesians staunchly opposed the move, launching attacks on the British army at many places. One reason why the British were keen to hand the colony back to Holland as quickly as possible was that most of the British soldiers serving in Indonesia were Indians who were also in favour of both India and Indonesia gaining independence.

The Dutch, however, failed to re-establish military control over their colony. They now tried to divide Indonesia into several independent states, with one of them ruled by a Sukarno-led government. Sukamo was forced to accept this solution under pressure from Britain and America. But this gave rise to a armed communist-led insurrection that was brutally suppressed with much bloodshed. The Dutch army re-established its control over Indonesia, arresting and imprisoning Sukarno. The move caused a world-wide furore, with the United Nations Organisation passing a resolution condemning the arrest. The UNO convened a round table conference at Bandung at which a consensus was reached on Indonesia's new government. On December 27, 1949, power was officially transferred to Indonesia, bringing an end to Dutch colonial rule.

India consistently supported the freedom movement in Indonesia and supported it in the UNO. Indonesia too joined the Non Alligned Movement along with India. It hosted in Bandung an important conference of 29 newly independent countries of Asia and Africa participated. The conference opposed all forms of colonialism and established certain principles for establishing peace and friendships among the countries.

Indonesia tried to establish a parliamentary democracy. The first general election was held in 1955, with several parties winning support in their respective regions. But these parties could not stay together to run a national government. During this period of instability, the Indonesian communist party, which had grown rapidly, extended its support to the Sukarno government. The communists put pressure on the government to take over and



Figure 10.3 A postage stamp issued by Indonesia to mark the Bandung conference. What does it depict?

nationalize the Dutch and British companies in the country. A land reform law was also enacted under which land was distributed to the poor peasants.

America became apprehensive that the communist influence would drive Indonesia into the Russian bloc. So it began helping Islamic fundamentalists to foment rebellions in different regions of the country. Sukarno declared president's rule with the backing of the communist parties, thus putting an end to parliamentary democracy. Many opposition parties were subsequently banned. But the growing strength of the communists posed a threat of their seizing power. To prevent this, a faction of the Indonesian army launched a mass campaign to eradicate communism, as did the Islamic fundamentalists. Communist cadres were slaughtered on a mass scale, some estimates placing the death toll at 5,00,000. Sukarno was ousted and the army installed Suharto as president of Indonesia, with America backing the transfer of power. Suharto's government ruled until 1998, after which democracy was, once again, established in Indonesia.

What role did Japan play in Indonesia's independence?

The Dutch colonial regime wanted to break Indonesia up into several independent states while the nationalists opposed the move. What was the reason for their conflicting policies?

Why couldn't democracy be established in Indonesia until 1998?

In what way was the nationalization of British and Dutch companies important for Indonesia's independence?

10.3.3 Vietnam

Vietnam's freedom struggle is a 20th century epic. The Vietnamese, mostly poor peasants, waged a long and formidable war against the world's two most powerful nations to gain their freedom. Vietnam, along with its neighbouring countries Laos and Cambodia, were French colonies. France treated its three colonies as a source of food-grain and other raw materials, forcing the peasants to grow crops for the international markets.

During the Great Depression of 1929, when food-grain prices fell drastically in the global markets, the indebted peasants of Vietnam were forced to sell their land to moneylenders and big landowners, then cultivate their own land as tenants. The French rulers did not want an educated middle class to emerge in its colony so it did not allow colleges and universities to be established in the country. The Vietnamese had to go to France to pursue higher education. Despite these restrictions, a fairly large number of people were able to pursue their education abroad and return home.



Figure 10.4 President of India Dr. Rajendra Prasad and Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru with Ho Chi Minh, President of Vietnam

During the Second World War, Japan captured Vietnam. The nationalist Vietnamese launched the Viet Minh movement under the leadership of communist ideologue Ho Chi Minh with the support of the USSR. When Japan faced defeat in the war in 1945, the Viet Minh formed an army, under the command of Vo Nguyen Giap, to capture power in Hanoi, the capital of the French colony.

After the war, France wanted to re-establish its control over Vietnam so it tried to install a puppet government that would act under its direction. The French army defeated Ho Chi Minh and drove him to seek refuge in the forests and mountains. But in May 1954, Gen Giap defeated the formidable French army using a clever strategy, forcing it to surrender. After this humiliating defeat, France decided to relinquish power in all its colonies.



Figure 10.5: A meeting in a North Vietnamese village to explain the land distribution law

But America was concerned about the growing influence of the communists in the region, so it decided to intervene. Taking over from France, it installed a puppet government in South Vietnam. The country was, thus, bifurcated, with the communists establishing their authority over North Vietnam, with Hanoi as their capital, and a former king becoming the head of the government in America-dominated South Vietnam. The Americans deployed their army in South Vietnam on the plea of saving the government.

Communist-controlled North Vietnam launched a land reform programme, abolishing feudal landlordism and making the peasants the owner-tillers of the land, with an upper limit being set on how much land a peasant could own. Thousands of feudal landowners were killed and their property was confiscated during the implementation of this law, with the poor peasants and landless labour becoming owners of their land after many generations. They became the staunchest supporters of the Viet Minh.

Vietnam soon became a pawn in the competition between America and the USSR. America wanted to destroy the Viet Minh and install its client government. Soviet Russia, on the other hand, gave military aid to the Viet Minh government to combat America on the battlefield. The Americans carpet bombed North Vietnam, using deadly chemical weapons (Agent Orange) that devastated all vegetation over a vast area, with not even a blade of grass growing for decades.

The horrifying pictures of this merciless devastation of life and property, beamed by the media, stunned the world, while the Vietnamese continuing to fight America despite the devastation. Thousands were killed on both sides. Gradually, the common citizens of USA began opposing what they perceived as a senseless war, with thousands participating in anti-war protests across the American continent. Many of them were veterans of the war who had seen the senseless killings and were revolted by them. They demanded that America withdraw from the war.

Eventually, in 1974, President Richard Nixon announced the withdrawal of American forces from Vietnam. The South Vietnamese government could not survive for long without American support and the two parts of Vietnam merged once more into a unified country on April 30, 1975.

Vietnam. The South Vietnamese government could not survive for long without American support and the two parts of Vietnam merged once more into a unified country on April 30, 1975Vietnam established parliamentary democracy but it extended recognition only to the communist party and its allies. So there was no multi-party democracy, with the communists controlling every facet of government and limiting citizen's rights. Thus, Vietnam could not transition to a fully democratic country.

What similarities and differences do you see in the national movements in India and Vietnam?

What impact did the rivalry between USA and USSR have on Vietnam?

What was the importance of land reform in Vietnam's freedom movement?

10.3.4 Africa

Most of the colonies in Africa were under British or French rule. While Britain was prepared to grant independence to its large colonies in Asia after 1945, it tried to retain its hold over its African colonies. France, too, did not wish to lose its African colonies. The French wanted to continue their rule or to protect their interests to the extent possible in case their colonies achieved their independence.

The imperialist countries exercised direct control over only the coastal regions of their African colonies where the main harbours were situated. They appointed tribal chieftains to rule over the interior regions. None of their colonies had a viable modern administrative system (unlike India where the British had developed an elaborate administrative system). Nor were the colonial rulers of Africa interested in developing modern education to create an indigenous educated middle class. So they established very few primary or higher educational institutions in the country. You will recall that it was this educated middle class that spearheaded the national freedom movement in India and sought to introduce social reform.

But Africa did see the development of a strong and organized working class, which was mainly employed in the railways, mines and harbours. This class began fighting for its rights after 1945, including parity between white and coloured workers. However, these struggles did not develop into nationalist freedom movements. This was because the working class was spread across the entire continent, so their struggles were more in the nature of a pan-African movement rather than individual country-specific movements. The result was that the working class developed a sense of pan-African brotherhood and unity in their struggle against imperialism.

What impact did a weak middle class and administration by tribal chieftains have on nationalism in Africa?

What problems did the working class face in Africa? How did the nationalist spirit develop in this class?

Among the African colonies, none of those under French rule had established a system of self-government even up to 1956. But the colonies did enjoy a limited right to participate in the French parliamentary elections, with African representatives being elected to the French assembly and some of them even becoming ministers. But there was no self-government in the African colonies.

The French defeat in Vietnam changed the situation in Africa. In that same year, the Algerian people launched a war of liberation against France that continued until 1958, when Algeria was granted independence. In Egypt, the nationalist government took over control of a major transport channel, the Suez Canal in 1956, which led France to join hands with Britain to attack it. But the imperialists were

defeated in the ensuing war. That defeat made it clear to both countries that they would have to grant freedom to their African colonies.

In 1958, France announced a referendum in all its colonies, saying it would grant independence to whichever country opted for freedom. Many of the large colonies voted for independence from France but some smaller countries opted to stay with their colonial masters. By 1960 they signed treaties with France under which the French would continue to play an important role in areas such as defence, education and economic development. The main reason for their continued dependence on France was that these countries lacked a credible local leadership, so they felt they needed French support until they could achieve a degree of stability. Political analysts see this relationship as a form of neocolonialism in which the colonies enjoyed limited freedom while France continued to control their economies and educational system.

With regard to the British colonies, Britain was keen on reducing its expenditure on its colonies because it was passing through difficult economic times. Hence, it also offered a similar proposal to its colonies in 1960, promising independence to those colonies opting for freedom. Large countries like Nigeria and Ghana accepted this proposal and gained their independence. But many other countries, which had large settlements of people of European descent who feared that their special rights and privileges would be compromised if the colonies became free, opposed the move. Their opposition complicated the independence process in these countries, most of which were located in the south of the African continent. They included South Africa, Rhodesia (now Zimbabwe), and Mozambique (a Portuguese colony). The African people in these countries continued to have no political rights even after independence was declared because they were ruled by their white minorities, who adopted apartheid policies to safeguard their power and authority. (Aparthied = a policy of separation of whites and non whites and restricting the rights of the non whites)

Britain could not effectively oppose these apartheid regimes because the British were not prepared to antagonize or fight the white minority. The African people had to wage a long and difficult struggle to fight apartheid, resorting to a range of methods - including guerilla warfare as well as a non-violent non-cooperation movement – to gain their freedom. These countries did eventually complete democracy between 1990 and 1994.



Figure 10.6: Prime Minister Julius Nyeyere being carried on the shoulders of the Tanzanian people after their country declared its independence

The history of the African colonies and their freedom struggles, thus, had their own special characteristics. For one, even though colonial rule had weakened the traditional power structures in most of the colonies, tribal loyalties still prevented the emergence of a binding national spirit among the people. So the governments formed after they gained independence were almost always shaped according to the interests of their former colonial masters rather than the needs of the people, with tension and competition continuing to prevail between the tribal clans.

Another defining feature of the African freedom struggles was the absence of a strong middle class and strong merchant-capitalist class. Lack of educational opportunities prevented the growth of a middle class while a mercantile class could not emerge because all trade and natural mineral resources were controlled by foreign companies. Also, none of the African countries had an effective army, administration or educational system. We shall now study the example of Nigeria to see how these challenges were surmounted.

Nigeria

Population-wise, Nigeria is the largest country in Africa with a population of 17 crore people. Before the advent of Britain, Nigeria did not exist as a separate country. The British combined the regions around the Niger River to establish their dominion, which they called Nigeria. But they retained direct authority and control only over the coastal regions, allowing local tribal chieftains to govern the interior regions.

The northern part of Nigeria was dominated by the Hausa-Fulani tribe, which was Muslim. The south-eastern part was ruled by the Ibo tribe while the southern part was under the control of the Yoruba tribe. The main income of these tribes came from the cultivation of palm oil, cotton and other commercial crops. After oil was discovered in the coastal areas, this mineral resource became the main revenue earner for the country.

The first stirring of nationalism in Nigeria arose among the coastal people who espoused the cause of a wider African nationalism and wanted to unify the three tribal regions into a single nation. Herbert Macaulay founded Nigeria's first political party, the Nigerian Democratic Party, in 1923. The party extended its support to the militant attacks on the British colonial government that occurred in 1930. In 1936, Nnamdi Azikiwe laid the foundation of the Nigerian Youth Movement. He wanted to unify all the tribes residing in the region under a single Nigerian identity. After the Second World War, Nigerian nationalism began to assert itself, the pillars of the movement being the workers' organisations and the soldiers who had served under the British during the war and were now returning home. In 1945, the labour movement declared a national general strike.



Figure 10.7: President Nnamdi Azikiwe

The Nigerian nationalists had to confront two challenges. First was to fight against colonial rule and second was to unite the many, often antagonistic, tribes and clans. The nationalist movement was stronger

in the south of the country than in the north, which created a north-south divide. Even within the south, tension – and even clashes - continued to prevail between the Ibo and Yoruba tribes. Thus, the nationalist movement in these three regions was led by regional parties until 1950. They included the Northern People's Congress in the north, The National Council for Nigeria and Cameroons in the east and The Action Group in the south.

Freedom and Weak Democracy : Aware of the growing non-violent democratic nationalist movement, the British decided to grant independence to Nigeria, with each of its constituent regions having self-rule. Nigeria gained independence on October 1, 1963, with Nnmadi Azikiwe as the first president. Unfortunately, the new government could not hold the country together and civil war soon broke out. In 1966, military rule was established, with Azikiwe and many of his associates being killed. The north gained dominance during the military regime and established its authority in Nigerian politics. Many attempts were subsequently made to re-establish civilian rule and democratic government but they were all unsuccessful. The military government worked hand-in-glove with the multinational oil corporations (which extended financial aid to the corrupt rulers) as a result of which Nigeria witnessed widespread corruption and suppression of civil rights.

After a long spell of military dictatorship, Nigeria elected a democratic government in 1999. But, to this day, the country's vital natural resources – oil exploration and production – continue to be controlled by foreign multinational corporations. The people cannot reap the full benefits of their resources. Instead, they face the growing threat of pollution of their water sources, rapid deforestation and environmental pollution along the coastal areas.

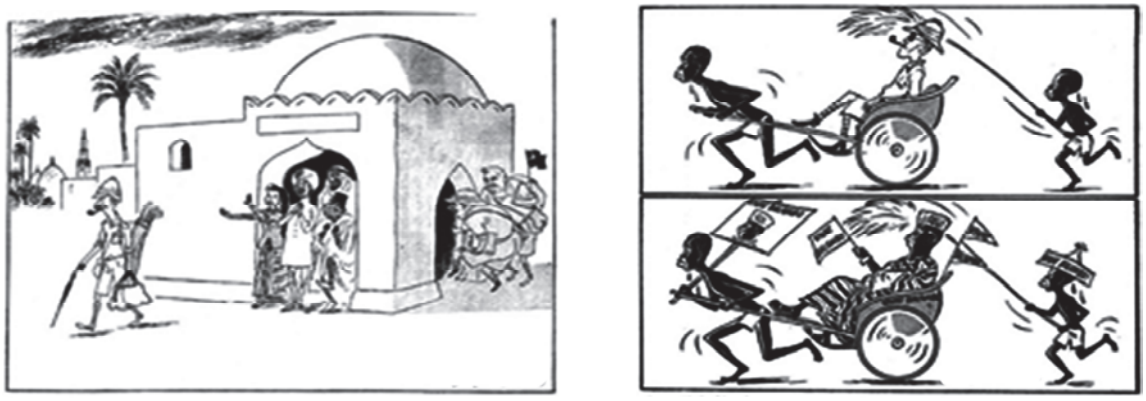


Figure 10.8: The process of decolonization. What do these two cartoons depict about this process?

10.4 Cold War and dissolution of the USSR: 1945 to 1992

In 1945, the USSR, the United States of America, Britain and other countries together defeated Germany and Japan. But the alliance did not last for long and soon USSR and America emerged as global competitors and adversaries. USSR believed in communism and wanted to propagate the socialist ideology across the world. It believed that a communist state would reduce inequalities in society by taking over control of a country's resources (factories, banks, mines etc) and using them for the benefit of all classes of people. America, on the other hand, believed in encouraging private enterprise, with individuals having the freedom to acquire and use all resources to meet the needs of society and the markets being able to function freely without government interference. America also propagated democracy and multi-party elections.

These were the ideological differences between the two global super-powers, with the USSR becoming a symbol of communism and America a symbol of capitalism. At the practical level, the two countries wanted to expand their spheres of influence by trade and military might. But the reality was that the two super-powers wanted to gain access to the resources of other countries for their own benefit.

Both countries sought to carve out their own spheres of influence in the treaties and negotiations conducted after the end of the Second World War. The Soviet sphere of influence included East Europe and, later, China, Korea and other countries. The rest of the world constituted the sphere of influence of America and its allies. Both countries accepted these boundaries but were always suspicious of each other's intentions. Initially, America had the upper hand because it possessed strategic nuclear weapons. But USSR also acquired these weapons after 1950.

The world saw rapid economic growth from 1945 to 1970. Tension continued to prevail between the two super-powers during this period, but it did not lead to the outbreak of war. However, the situation changed after 1970 as economic recession set in across the world. Tensions rose anew between the two super-powers who possessed nuclear arsenals that could not only destroy each other but also annihilate the whole world. However, this potential to destroy the world prevented them from confronting each other directly in a war. Instead, they fought proxy wars in their colonies and client states. For example, a permanent state of war existed between North and South Korea and North and South Vietnam after these countries were bifurcated in 1950 and 1954 respectively. USSR supported the northern factions in both countries while America came to the aid of the southern factions.



Figure 10.9: A peace march in Germany during the peace movement in 1980s

A similar situation was created following the bifurcation of India and Pakistan, with USSR supporting India and America supporting Pakistan. The conflict between the Arab countries and Israel in West Asia was another proxy arena for the super-powers as were the independence movements in Angola, Namibia and Mozambique in southern Africa.

More dangerous than even these proxy wars was the arms race between the two super-powers. In spite of knowing that neither one of them could win a nuclear war, the fear of a confrontation led both countries to develop even deadlier nuclear weapons in ever-larger quantities. These weapons were deployed in their military bases across the globe, bringing all countries within their range. So the threat of nuclear devastation hung over the world as the super-powers kept threatening to use their weaponry in areas of tension. Another very real fear was that a technical glitch could accidentally and unintentionally trigger a nuclear weapon. That's why, from 1975 to 1999, the entire world stood on the precipice of mutually assured destruction leading to nuclear annihilation.

Seeing the gravity of the situation caused by the arms race, the common people around the world, in particular from Europe and America where most of the nuclear weapons were deployed, began to launch peace movements and stage demonstrations at nuclear facilities. Lakhs of women, men and children in different countries participated in these movements and demanded that their governments unconditionally abolish nuclear weapons, destroy their arsenals, and prohibit other countries from deploying such weapons on their soil.

In the absence of democratic rights, USSR did not see such widespread movements but even there the intellectual class extended its support to these world peace movements. The pressure of the people forced the American and Russian leaders to think in terms of a nuclear free world. Both countries began a series of Strategic Arms Limitation Talks (SALT) that, after many initial failures, led to eventual success in 1998.. The presidents of America and USSR, Ronald Reagan and Mikhail Gorbachev, signed a nuclear disarmament treaty in Reykjavik, the capital of Iceland, and Washington, the capital of America. This treaty made it incumbent on both nations to reduce their nuclear arsenals and practically stop the testing of new weapons. This treaty brought an end to the Cold War.

But the Cold War left a deep impact on the world. Apart from America and USSR, other countries were also forced to spend their resources on procuring weapons and strengthening their armed forces instead of developing themselves and improving the lives of their people. Thus, the majority of countries, including USSR, were economically crippled, barring those that depended on their armaments industry for economic growth. These countries earned huge profits.

Taking advantage of USSR's deteriorating economic condition, many East European countries that were getting restless under Soviet control broke away to declare their independence. This phase saw the reunification of East and West Germany, an event that was symbolised by the dramatic destruction of the Berlin wall, which divided the capital between the two wings, by the common people. Soviet Russia could not survive these happenings and unexpectedly collapsed in December 1991 when it was officially dissolved. In place of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics, 15 separate republics that opted for capitalism and electoral democracy came into being, bringing the curtain down on a unique attempt to bring equality and socialism to the modern world.

The world still struggles with another consequence of the Cold War. When USSR sought to influence the Arab countries in their fight against America and Israel, America spread the word among the Arabs that Islam was in danger from communism. Similarly, when USSR invaded Afghanistan and established its control over the country, America encouraged fundamentalist Islamic groups and armed them with formidable weapons to fight against the Russians. Both Russia and America also equipped groups in other countries of the world



Figure 10.10: Reagan and Gorbachev at the Reykjavik conference

to carry out guerrilla warfare against their governments. After the collapse of the Soviet Union, these groups are now spreading their terrorist activities across the world. The terrorist threat to the world, thus, began after the close of the Cold War.

EXERCISES

1. Fill in the blanks:
   a) Indonesian nationalist …… was the country's first president.
   b) Vietnamese revolutionary …… was the country's first president.
   c) Nigerian nationalist …… was the country's first president.
   d) Indonesia's freedom movement sought independence from ……
   e) Vietnam fought against …… and …… in its freedom movement.
2. What were the similarities and differences between the Indian freedom movement and Africa's freedom movements?
3. Three Asian countries – India, Vietnam and Indonesia – carried out land reforms after they became independent. Compare the land reforms in these three countries.
4. What were the problems in establishing democracy in Indonesia and Nigeria? How did India resolve these problems?
5. What was the role of nuclear weapons in the Cold War?
6. How was nuclear disarmament made possible?
7. What impacts of the Cold War can you see in the world today?

PROJECT WORK

Find out about the freedom movement in any other country by searching the internet or referring to a library. Prepare a poster exhibition of your research. Display it in the class.